

CMP-09 · COMPETENCY FRAMEWORKS

Behavioural and leadership competencies

The behaviours that decide whether a correct number changes anything

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

A correct forecast that nobody acts on has changed nothing. This document sets out the five behaviours that determine whether a controls, finance or delivery professional is listened to — raising a number that is unwelcome, holding a position under pressure and releasing it on evidence, stating what is not known, making a trade-off legible rather than winning an argument, and owning delegated and AI-derived output — with the observable indicators for each, the escalation ladder that supports them, and the organisational conditions without which none of them survives.

— About this document

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Contents

1. Behaviour is not a separate framework.....	4
2. The five behaviours	4
2.1 Raising a number that will be unwelcome.....	5
2.2 Holding a position under pressure — and releasing it on evidence	5
2.3 Saying what you do not know	5
2.4 Making the trade-off legible rather than winning the argument.....	6
2.5 Owning the output, including what a system produced.....	6
3. The escalation ladder	7
4. The conditions that make these behaviours possible.....	7
5. Evidencing behaviour	8
6. How this goes wrong	8
7. Worked example: the wording of a qualification	9
8. Checklist	9
Related	10
Sources and standards.....	10
Status and version	10

Behavioural and leadership competencies

In one paragraph. A correct forecast that nobody acts on has changed nothing. This document sets out the five behaviours that determine whether a controls, finance or delivery professional is listened to — raising a number that is unwelcome, holding a position under pressure and releasing it on evidence, stating what is not known, making a trade-off legible rather than winning an argument, and owning delegated and AI-derived output — with the observable indicators and counter-indicators for each, the escalation ladder that supports them, and the organisational conditions without which none of them survives.

Who this is for. Project controls managers, cost and planning leads, project and programme managers, and the executives who decide whether these behaviours are rewarded or quietly penalised in their organisations.

— 1. Behaviour is not a separate framework

The Institute does not publish a behavioural competency framework alongside the technical ones, and the omission is deliberate. Behaviour is inside the published sets, because it is inseparable from the technical work.

It appears explicitly. PML-AI names project leadership, stakeholder leadership, governance and human accountability. PCL-AI names project controls governance and human validation; PFL-AI names human validation. These are behavioural competencies with technical content, not soft additions.

It also appears implicitly, in every level descriptor at professional and above. CMP-02 §2.3 defines professional level as deciding the method where procedure is silent **and defending the decision to someone who wanted a different answer**. That second clause is a behaviour. The scale cannot be climbed by technical capability alone, because the level is defined partly by conduct under pressure.

There is a structural reason this matters more in project controls, project finance and delivery management than in many disciplines. The output of the work is a number that constrains other people's plans, budgets, bonuses and reputations. The number is produced by someone who usually does not hold authority over the project, is often junior to the people it constrains, and frequently has to deliver it to the person whose performance it describes. That configuration puts consistent pressure in one direction: the forecast is asked to be lower, the risk to be smaller, the date to be earlier. Nobody has ever been asked to make a forecast worse.

— 2. The five behaviours

Each is stated with observable indicators, counter-indicators, and the evidence that would demonstrate it. Indicators are observable actions, not attitudes; nobody can assess "integrity", and everybody can assess whether a forecast moved before or after the client found out.

2.1 Raising a number that will be unwelcome

What it is. Reporting a deterioration at the point you are confident of it, rather than at the point it becomes undeniable — while there is still time for the information to be useful.

Observable indicators. The forecast moved in a period when no external event forced it. The escalation is dated earlier than the event that confirmed it. The person raised the issue in a written record, not only in a corridor. They brought the size of the problem and its basis, not a warning that things "may be tight". They said what they wanted done about it.

Counter-indicators. Forecasts that move only in the month a client audit is announced. Deterioration disclosed in a footnote or a verbal aside. A record showing the person "flagged concerns" without a number or a date. A pattern of large single-period corrections, which is the signature of accumulated withholding.

Evidence. A dated forecast note showing an upward revision and its basis, together with the outcome. A report qualification in writing. An escalation email with its date, and the subsequent record of what happened.

2.2 Holding a position under pressure — and releasing it on evidence

What it is. Two behaviours that only count together. Maintaining a position when it is challenged by someone with more authority and no new evidence; and changing it promptly and publicly when new evidence arrives.

Observable indicators. The person can state, in advance, what would change their mind — a specific piece of evidence, not a threshold of pressure. When challenged, they ask what is being asserted rather than restating their number louder. When they concede, they say what changed and update the record. When they do not concede, they offer a route to resolve it: an independent check, a sample verification, a joint walk of the work.

Counter-indicators. Positions that change after a meeting with a senior person and no new information, with no record of why. Positions that never change, which is not integrity but a different failure — the person has stopped processing evidence. Conceding privately while maintaining the original position in the record, or the reverse.

Evidence. A challenge and its resolution, documented on both sides. A position reversed with the reason recorded contemporaneously. A dispute escalated to an independent check, and the outcome.

2.3 Saying what you do not know

What it is. Distinguishing, out loud and in the record, between what has been verified, what has been assumed, and what is unknown — and saying what it would take to know it.

Observable indicators. Reports carry an explicit assumptions section that changes between periods rather than being copied forward. The person answers a question with "I don't know; I can find out by Thursday" and then does. Ranges are used where the situation warrants a range, with the drivers of the spread named. Unverified inputs are labelled as unverified in the document, not just in the author's mind.

Counter-indicators. Confident single-point answers to questions the data cannot support. An assumptions section identical to last quarter's. Precision used as a proxy for confidence — a forecast quoted to the nearest unit when the underlying accrual is an estimate.

Evidence. Reports with live assumption registers. A documented refusal to provide a number on inadequate data, with the alternative offered and the date it was delivered. A stated range with its basis, later compared to outturn.

2.4 Making the trade-off legible rather than winning the argument

What it is. Presenting a decision-maker with the actual choice and its consequences, in a form they can decide from, rather than advocating for the answer you prefer and treating disagreement as a failure of theirs.

Observable indicators. Options are presented with consequences on the dimensions the decision-maker cares about — cost, date, scope, risk exposure — not only the one the analyst cares about. The recommendation is stated and separated from the analysis, so the decision-maker can accept the analysis and reject the recommendation. The person can articulate the strongest version of the option they are advising against. After the decision, they implement it and record any residual concern once, rather than relitigating it monthly.

Counter-indicators. One real option and two straw men. Analysis that stops precisely where it would have become inconvenient. Escalation of a decision that has already been properly made, in the hope of a different answer. A residual concern raised for the first time after the outcome is known.

Evidence. An options paper with genuine alternatives and comparable consequence statements. A decision record showing the recommendation, the decision taken and any recorded dissent. A decision you disagreed with, implemented, and whose consequences you tracked honestly.

2.5 Owning the output, including what a system produced

What it is. Being the person answerable for a number, including when the analysis came from a model, a tool or a team — and declining to release what you cannot stand behind.

Observable indicators. The person can explain a figure produced by an AI-assisted or automated process in their own words, including its limitations. They can name what they checked and against what. They have declined to issue something within the reporting deadline because it could not be verified, and said so rather than issuing it silently. They do not attribute an error to a tool or to a junior colleague in a forum where neither is present.

Counter-indicators. "The model produced it." "That comes from the system." A signature on a document whose method its signatory cannot describe. Errors traced downward in public and credit traced upward in private.

Evidence. A validation record naming what was checked and found. A withheld or qualified deliverable with the reason recorded. A post-incident review in which the person owned a failure in a process they designed. See CMP-08 §7 for the validation mechanics and CMP-05 §4.9 for accountability at leader level.

— 3. The escalation ladder

Behaviour needs a route, or it becomes a choice between silence and resignation. The ladder below moves only when the previous rung has been tried and recorded, and each rung leaves evidence.

1. **Fix it in the record.** Correct the number, note the correction and its basis. Most issues stop here.
2. **Raise it with the person who owns the number.** Directly, with the basis, and with what you want changed. Confirm the conversation in writing the same day — not as a threat, but because a contemporaneous note is the only version that survives.
3. **Qualify the report in writing.** If a report must be issued and you cannot sign it cleanly, say what you could not verify and what the number excludes. §7 gives the wording. This is the most under-used rung on the ladder and the most powerful, because it is factual, proportionate and permanent.
4. **Escalate to the next governance tier.** The project board, the steering committee, or the function's head — whichever the governance framework names. Bring the number, the basis, the attempts already made, and the specific decision you are asking for.
5. **Escalate to the accountable officer, formally.** In writing, with the record. At this rung the matter has stopped being a disagreement about a number and has become a governance failure.
6. **Treat it as a conduct matter.** Where a number is being misstated knowingly, or where you are being instructed to misstate one, this is no longer a controls question. ETH-01 — The PCI code of ethics and professional conduct and ETH-03 — Reporting numbers under pressure own this ground, including the protections and the obligations.

Two rules govern the ladder. **Proportionality:** starting at rung 4 for a rung-2 problem destroys the credibility you will need later. **Documentation at every rung:** the record is not for a tribunal, it is for the ordinary case where three months later everyone remembers the conversation differently.

— 4. The conditions that make these behaviours possible

An organisation cannot certify a behaviour it punishes, and most organisations punish these behaviours without deciding to. Four conditions determine whether the behaviours in §2 are available:

- **A forecast can move without someone being blamed for the movement.** Where a deteriorating forecast is treated as the forecaster's failure, forecasts stop deteriorating. The observable test: when a forecast worsened last quarter, was the first question what changed? or who allowed this?
- **The controls function reports somewhere other than solely to the person whose performance it measures.** Complete dependence on the project manager for appraisal, allocation and progression makes independent reporting a personal-cost decision every month. A dotted line to a functional head is a structural control, not an organisational preference.
- **There is time to verify.** A reporting cycle that leaves two days between data cut-off and board pack makes physical verification impossible, and then treats its absence as an individual failing.
- **Bad news is received, not punished, in the forum where it is delivered.** People calibrate to what happens to the last person who raised something. Everyone in the room learns from that, and they learn it in one meeting.

For an employer using this framework, the practical consequence is uncomfortable: if you are assessing staff against §2 while running an organisation that fails §4, you are assessing their appetite for personal cost rather than their competence.

— 5. Evidencing behaviour

Behaviour is evidenced badly by testimonial and well by contemporaneous record. Four artefact types carry almost all of it:

- **The dated note.** A forecast note, an escalation email, a file note of a conversation, written the same day. Its value is entirely in its date.
- **The qualification.** A written statement in a deliverable of what could not be verified or what is excluded. It is public, permanent and hard to reinterpret later.
- **The reversal.** A position changed with the reason recorded, which evidences §2.2 more strongly than any number of held positions.
- **The reconciliation over time.** What you said in month 6 set against what happened by month 12. Very few candidates offer this, and it is the single most persuasive behavioural evidence available, in both directions: a professional who was wrong and says so has demonstrated more than one who was right.

A behavioural claim with no contemporaneous artefact is a story. Not necessarily untrue — but not assessable, and CMP-10 §2 explains why an assessor cannot give it weight.

— 6. How this goes wrong

Behaviour is assessed as personality. "Confident communicator", "team player", "strong presence" — none of which is observable in the sense required, and all of which correlate with things a competency framework must not select for. Assess actions with dates.

Escalation is confused with courage. Escalating everything is not a behavioural strength; it is a failure of the judgement in §3, and it exhausts the credibility needed for the escalation that matters.

Holding a position is confused with being right. A person who never changes their view is not reliable; they have stopped updating. The competency is the pair of behaviours in §2.2, and evidence for only one half of it is evidence of the wrong thing.

The qualification is used as a weapon. A report qualified in aggressive or accusatory terms invites a fight about tone and buries the substance. The wording in §7 is deliberately flat: it states what was and was not verified, and nothing about anyone's motives.

Bad news is delivered at the wrong size. A three-week slip presented with the gravity of a project failure trains the audience to discount you; a serious problem mentioned in passing under "any other business" is a disclosure that will not protect anyone, including its author.

The organisation certifies behaviour it structurally prevents. See §4. A behavioural rating scale deployed into an environment that punishes the behaviour produces uniformly high ratings and no information.

Nobody records anything until it is a dispute. By then the record is written by people who know how it turned out, and the version most favourable to its author is the one that gets written. The whole behavioural evidence base depends on notes made before anyone knew the ending.

— 7. Worked example: the wording of a qualification

Illustrative wording; the figures within it are illustrative. A cost report must be issued to a project board on the due date. Two problems remain unresolved: the December progress claim has not been verified against physical progress, and two instructed variations are unagreed. The professional cannot delay the report and cannot sign it cleanly.

The qualification, placed in the report's summary rather than in an appendix:

Basis and limitations of this report. The forecast at completion of 4,565,000 cost units assumes the remaining work is performed at the cost performance index achieved to date (0.909) and that no further scope is instructed. It includes agreed variations of 150,000 cost units. It **excludes** two instructed but unpriced variations, assessed by the project at 90,000 cost units against the contractor's submitted 140,000 cost units, and any cost consequence of the extension-of-time claim intimated on 12 November, which is not yet quantified. The December progress claim has not been verified against physical progress; verification is scheduled for 14 January. If the claim proves overstated, the earned value and therefore the forecast will move adversely.

Four properties make this work, and they are worth copying:

1. **It states the number and its assumptions in the same breath**, so nobody can quote the forecast without the condition attached.
2. **It separates what is included from what is excluded**, and gives the excluded items a range rather than a silence.
3. **It names a date for resolution.** A qualification with no closing action becomes permanent furniture and stops being read.
4. **It attributes nothing to anyone.** No motive, no blame, no adjectives. It is a statement about the report, which makes it very difficult to argue with and very easy to act on.

The consequence of writing it is that the board can no longer treat 4,565,000 as a settled figure — which is the entire point, and the reason the paragraph is harder to write than the model that produced the number.

— 8. Checklist

For a professional deciding how to handle a number nobody wants:

- [] Am I confident of this, or confident that it is likely? Which am I about to say?
- [] Is it early enough for the information to be useful, and if not, why did it take this long?
- [] Do I have the number, the basis and the specific decision I am asking for?
- [] Have I written it down today, with a date?
- [] What evidence would change my mind, and have I said so out loud?
- [] If I must issue this, what exactly can I not verify, and does the report say so in its summary?
- [] Which rung of the escalation ladder is proportionate — and have I tried the one below it?

- [] Am I presenting a decision or advocating a preference? Have I stated the strongest case against my own recommendation?
- [] For any AI-assisted or delegated figure: can I explain it in my own words, and did I check it?
- [] After the decision, will I implement it properly, or relitigate it monthly?

For an employer using this document to assess others: answer §4 first.

— Related

- [CMP-02 – Competency levels and how they are evidenced](#) — why professional level is defined partly by conduct under challenge
- [CMP-05 – PML-AI: the twenty-four competencies](#) — project leadership, stakeholder leadership and human accountability, defined and levelled
- [CMP-10 – Assessing competence – evidence, rubrics and moderation](#) — how behavioural claims are tested without assessing personality
- [ETH-01 – The PCI code of ethics and professional conduct](#) — the obligations behind rung 6 of the ladder
- [ETH-03 – Reporting numbers under pressure – a casebook](#) — the cases this document's behaviours are drawn from
- [CAR-05 – Into project controls leadership](#) — the career transition in which these behaviours become the job

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform certification catalogue ([backend/Data/MultiCert.cs](#)), verified August 2026 — the seeded competency sets, in which the behavioural competencies named in §1 appear.
- PCI Body of Knowledge domains 4 and 13 ([docs/bok/](#)) — performance management and management reporting, and AI for project controls. Cited by domain; not reproduced.
- No case studies, quotations, organisations or individuals are cited in this document. The wording in §7 is an illustrative construction, not a reproduction of any real report.

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